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Skill 1: **Calming** the Body and **Mind**

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Discuss the importance of **Body literacy** and recognize the **emotional state** in a given situation
- Identify the right vocabulary to name the different **sensations in the body**
- Define the **resilient zone** and its connection to **emotional regulation**
- Recognize when you are out of the resilience zone
- Discuss the role and importance of the **parasympathetic nervous system**
- Use tools for better emotional regulation

Introduction

Imagine you're about to go on a fun weekend road trip. Your bags are packed, your fuel tank is full, and you've got your road trip playlist ready. You're excited and ready to hit the road. There's some traffic, but you're not worried. You'll soon be speeding through the highway.

But then, thirty minutes into your drive, you see smoke coming from your car/bike engine. You have to slow down and stop. You start to regret not getting your car serviced last week. To make things worse, the driver behind you starts honking, and you get **angry**. You shout back, **feeling annoyed** at the driver, your car, and most of all, yourself.

Does this sound familiar? Our minds and bodies are like that car engine – they need regular care and attention. The first step to improving your life and your relationships is to focus on your own well-being. You can do this by developing:

- **Inner calm**
- **Self-control**
- **Emotional intelligence**
- **Self-compassion**

These skills help you build a strong foundation for being kinder to others and creating a more peaceful society. It might seem complicated, but don't worry. In this course, we'll take it one step at a time.

Let's start with skill 1: Calming Body and Mind, learning how to achieve a greater degree of **inner calm**.

The nervous system reacts to external and internal stimuli very quickly. Difficult emotions or thoughts usually begin as bodily sensations and are often leading indicators of **stress, anxiety, fear and depression** as well as **states of joy, calm and clarity**. Your body and mind are deeply connected and anything you experience in one will immediately and automatically affect the other.

In this module, we will:

1. Learn to recognize the various sensations in the body, therefore developing better body literacy
2. Explore the resilient zone and its connection to emotional regulation
3. Learn to use tools like **tracking, grounding and resourcing**

To get started, simply take your time going through this module. Be sure to explore the practices and techniques we've outlined to help you work towards achieving a calm, yet alert state of mind. Mastering this skill will also help pave the way for the other skills in this course, such as developing **mindfulness, compassion, gratitude, and common humanity**.

So, let's get started, shall we?

Sensation Words

Calming our body and mind starts with observing the various sensations in our body. Sensation words refer to the language of our autonomic nervous system that registers safety and regulates our organs accordingly. While emotion words help us express how we are feeling, body sensations can provide additional information.

Body literacy is the ability to understand and interpret these sensations in our bodies. It involves recognizing and responding to physical signals and cues, which helps in identifying emotional states and maintaining overall well-being.

Developing body literacy can improve your self-awareness and enhance your ability to manage emotions effectively. By paying attention to your body's signals, you can cultivate a greater degree of **inner calm, self-control, emotional intelligence, and self-compassion**.

Resilient Zone

The sensations in our body are an indicator of whether we are in or out of our resilient zone. According to Elaine Miller, of the Trauma Research Institute, a resilient zone is defined as, a state of equilibrium where we feel balanced and capable of dealing with **stressful or traumatic experiences**. It doesn't stop us from experiencing emotions such as anger or sadness, but it may help us retain control over our thoughts and actions in such moments.

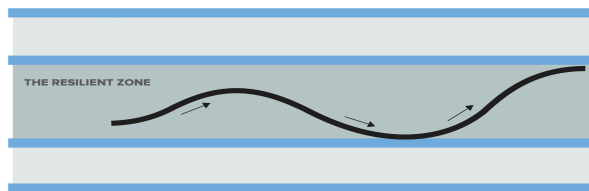
Being in the resilient zone is closely linked to emotional regulation. When we are in our resilient zone, we can handle stress and bounce back from challenges more effectively. This state helps us manage our emotions, so we don't overreact to situations and can stay calm and focused.

In everyday life, being in the resilient zone might look like staying calm during a tough exam, **not losing your temper** in a heated argument, or managing anxiety before a big presentation. When we are out of our resilient zone, we might **feel overwhelmed/nervous, anxious, or overly stressed**, and it becomes **harder to think clearly and make good decisions**.

Developing body literacy and understanding our resilient zone can greatly enhance our emotional regulation. By paying attention to the sensations in our body, we can notice early signs of stress/anxiety and take steps to return to our resilient zone.

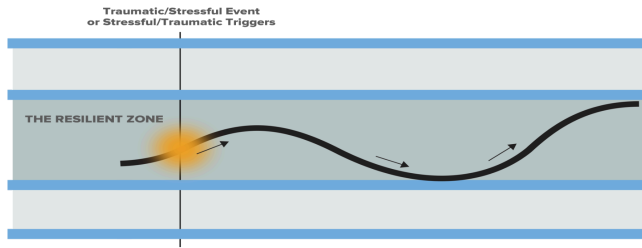
In the next section, we will discuss the resilience zone in detail and what happens when we are out of the resilience zone.

Resilient Zone

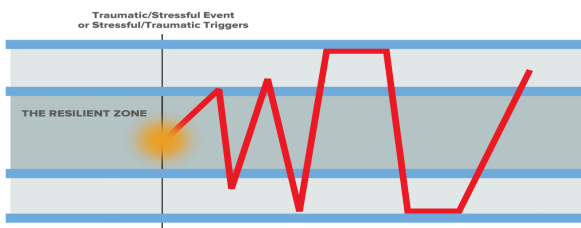


Based on the Community Resiliency Model, the Trauma Resource Institute

As shown in the wave depiction, the Resilient Zone is where we experience the full range of emotions while staying balanced and in control. In this zone, we are **calm, strong, and able to make our best decisions**. It's not necessarily our "happy place" because we can still feel sadness but remain resilient and calm. We can call this the "okay zone." This zone allows us to respond to challenges with a clear mind and stable emotions.



Do we always stay in our resilient zone? Not really. We all face various stressful situations every day, and when stressed, our nervous system can be thrown out of balance, causing us to leave our resilient zone. For example, a **tough exam, an argument with a friend, or even a loud noise can disrupt our inner balance.**



It is natural to be bumped out of the Resilient Zone. The graphic demonstrates the natural rhythm of the nervous system (the black line) and shows how a trigger or a traumatic/stressful event (represented by the orange thunderbolt) can cause the nervous system to get bumped out of the Resilient Zone (the red line). These triggers can be anything from a **sudden loud noise to a reminder of a past trauma.**

For some of us, especially due to stressful or traumatic experiences, leaving the Resilient Zone may happen regularly. When out of this zone, we might feel constantly on edge ("stuck on high"), where everything **seems to irritate** us and we **can't relax**. Or, we might feel depressed and **tired** ("stuck on low"), where we **lack energy and motivation**. Sometimes, it can feel like being on a roller coaster, fluctuating between these extremes, making it **hard to maintain a sense of normalcy/balance.**

Dysregulation can be triggered by almost anything that reminds a person of a traumatic or stressful event, such as a **smell, sight, sound, touch, or body position**. This can happen even without our conscious awareness. For instance, a particular song might bring back memories of a difficult time, causing an emotional reaction.

Understanding the Resilient Zone and how to maintain it is crucial for emotional regulation and overall well-being. By developing body literacy, we can recognize when we are out of our

resilient zone and take steps to return to it. This involves paying attention to our body's signals and using techniques that we will discuss later in this module.

Sympathetic and Parasympathetic Nervous System

Our nervous system has two main parts: an alerting, stressed-out part and a calming, relaxing part. When we are stressed or when our brain perceives danger, our sympathetic nervous system gets activated to respond to threats. This leads to the **fight, flight, or freeze response**, where our **heartbeat increases** and **blood flow** to our limbs prepares us for action.

On the other hand, our body also has the capacity to calm us down after a stressful incident through the parasympathetic nervous system. This system helps us **relax** and **recover**. The part of our nervous system that we use the most becomes the strongest, so it's important to intentionally train our bodies to strengthen the parasympathetic response. Without this, our nervous system can become **unhealthy**, **constantly stuck in a state of stress**.

A healthy nervous system can use both the activating response and the calming response effectively. An unhealthy nervous system sees **threats** everywhere and gets stuck in a state of hyper-arousal (always on edge) or hypo-arousal (feeling numb and disconnected).

Spending more time in the calm state, or the resilient zone, is essential for our well-being. The good news is that we can influence which part of our nervous system is activated and train ourselves to strengthen the parasympathetic nervous system. This helps us stay in the resilient zone for longer periods.

To help us achieve this, we can practice various exercises. The next section introduces three powerful tools that can assist us when we are knocked out of the resilient zone: **tracking**, **grounding**, and **resourcing**.

These tools help us become more aware of our body's signals, anchor ourselves in the present moment, and draw on positive resources to manage stress effectively.

Tracking

Tracking involves noticing or paying attention to what is happening inside your body at the present moment. It helps you determine if the sensation is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. By sitting or staying with sensations that are pleasant or neutral, you can build a stronger connection to your body's signals and foster resilience.

Tracking activity

Activity Prep: Download the sensation words list [here](#), before the activity

1. Sit in a comfortable position
2. Once you are ready, place the palms of your hands together and keep rubbing them back and forth

3. Now, observe what you are experiencing on the inside of your body, can you identify the pleasant or neutral sensations in your body?
4. See if you can identify sensations rather than emotions or thoughts
5. Refer to the sensation words list you downloaded before this activity. Make a note of the different sensations you are experiencing in your journal.

By practicing tracking, you enhance your ability to stay in the present moment and develop a deeper awareness of your body's responses. This can significantly improve your emotional regulation and overall well-being.

Grounding

Grounding involves noticing the direct contact of an object with your body that provides a sense of support and stability. When the nervous system is dysregulated, it can be helpful to focus on a part of the body that feels grounded or supported. For example, if you are sitting in a chair and your feet feel firm and supported on the ground, you can notice this sensation and sit with it for a few moments.

Grounding can be particularly useful during moments of high stress, anxiety, or when you feel overwhelmed. It helps bring your attention back to the present moment, creating a sense of stability and calm.

Grounding Practice

- Find a position that is most comfortable for you. You could sit on a chair, a cushion on the floor, or even stand leaning against a wall.
- Bring your attention to the part of your body that is in contact with another object. It could be your back against the chair or the wall, your feet on the floor, or your hands on your lap.
- As you do this, notice the various sensations in your body. Focus on the pleasant or neutral sensations and rest your attention there.
- Continue this for as long as you feel comfortable, allowing your body to experience a sense of support and stability.

Grounding helps to bring your attention to the present moment and can create a feeling of being anchored and secure.

You can use grounding in any situation, especially when you are in a crowded market, during exams, interviews, or meetings. To ground yourself, simply bring your attention to a part of your body that is in contact with an object. It could be the chair you are sitting on, a pen you are holding, a piece of jewelry you are wearing, or anything around you at that moment.

Resourcing

A Resource is any person, place, thing, memory, or part of yourself that makes you feel calm, pleasant, peaceful, strong, or resilient. Resources can be unique to each of us, and we can have multiple resources. To practice resourcing, one brings the resource to mind as vividly as possible. This practice helps us feel supported and can significantly enhance our resilience and emotional regulation.

Build your own resource

- Think of a resource – it could be a place you loved visiting in the past, a person you like the most, or even an activity you enjoy doing.
- Now, picture it in vivid detail/Now, imagine it clearly. Try to include as many of your senses as appropriate/ Use as many senses as you can. (colors, textures, sounds, tastes, etc.).
- As you do this, notice the various sensations in your body. Rest your attention on the pleasant or neutral sensations/ Focus on the pleasant or neutral sensations.
- Make a note of the sensations you notice in your journal/ Write down the sensations you notice in your journal.

By visualizing and engaging with your resource, you can create a **sense of calm and stability** that helps you manage stress and maintain emotional balance.

You could use resourcing in situations where you are feeling low on energy/motivation, before a stressful event, or after a difficult experience.

Quiz (Purpose and Use)

What it is:A few short questions shown after the lesson and activities.

Why we use it:

To check whether the student understood body sensations and the resilient zone

To help the student reflect on what they felt during the activities

To help the chatbot know the student's current understanding and state

Example quiz questions:

Name 3 body sensations you noticed during the activity.

In which situation are you out of the resilient zone?

What tool will you use when you feel overwhelmed?

Outcome:Improves awareness and helps the chatbot give better support.

Video (Purpose and Use)

What it is:Short guided videos for grounding and resourcing practices.

Why we use it:

Some students understand better by watching rather than reading

Helps students follow the practice correctly

Useful when a student feels very stressed and needs quick calming

Video types in this skill:

Guided grounding practice (how to feel support from chair/floor)

Guided resourcing visualization (how to imagine a safe place/person)

Outcome:Helps students quickly return to a calm state when they are anxious or overwhelmed.



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Skill 2: Ethical Mindfulness

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define **Ethical Mindfulness**
- Identify the three components of ethical mindfulness.
- Describe the significance of **attention stability**.
- Demonstrate how to practice mindfulness in daily activities
- Analyze scenarios to determine how ethical mindfulness can influence outcomes

Definition of Ethical Mindfulness

Think of a time when you said something in a fit of **anger**, something you didn't mean. What happened after that incident? Did you **feel regret and embarrassment**? Many of us have experienced this, and it often leaves us **wishing we had acted differently**. Skill two of this course addresses exactly that: how to **act in accordance with our values** even in challenging situations.

Ethical Mindfulness is defined as the ability to maintain one's identity and **core values while speaking and acting accordingly. It involves living in a way that consistently reflects our principles, even under **stress** or **pressure**.**

To illustrate this concept, consider these scenarios:

Scenario 1: Imagine you receive unexpected criticism from your boss. Your initial reaction might be to defend yourself or lash out/show anger. However, with ethical mindfulness, you can **take a moment to breathe**, **reflect on your values**, and **respond calmly and constructively/positively**

Scenario 2: Picture a situation where a friend **says something hurtful**. Instead of reacting **impulsively**, you **pause and remember your value of maintaining strong relationships**. This helps you respond with understanding and find a solution rather than starting a fight/conflict

Scenario 3: Think about being **under immense pressure** before an **exam**. Ethical **mindfulness** can guide you to **manage your stress** in a way that aligns with your **value of integrity**, so you **avoid cheating** or **taking unethical shortcuts**.

Ethical Mindfulness comprises 3 components - Heedfulness, Mindfulness and Awareness.

Components of Ethical Mindfulness

Heedfulness

We may have noticed that sometimes we pay less attention to the way we speak or act, but after the event, we realize that our speech and actions may have caused harm to ourselves or others. The first step in the process of ethical mindfulness is to be aware of how our thoughts and actions **s t h a t** can be harmful to ourselves and others.

An ancient Indian metaphor used to teach this level of heedfulness is that of a person who was ordered to carry a bowl filled right to the brim with hot sesame oil, while a guard holding a drawn sword walked behind him. If the person spilled even a drop of sesame oil, the guard was instructed to chop his head off. Clearly, in such a situation, we would be extremely careful. This metaphor explains what heedfulness is: **a sense of care** and **restraint with regard to things we recognize as dangerous**. Often, however, we lack heedfulness and only realize our mistakes in **hindsight**./ An old Indian metaphor teaches heedfulness with a story: a person had to carry a bowl of hot sesame oil while a guard with a sword followed him. If he spilled even a drop, the guard would be ordered to chop off his head. This shows heedfulness as being very careful about dangerous things. Often, we don't practice heedfulness and only see our mistakes later.

Reflect on this:

You're scrolling through **social media** and see a post that makes you angry. You **feel like leaving a harsh comment**.

How will you use heedfulness in this situation?

Mindfulness

There are several popular definitions of mindfulness. In SEEK, we define mindfulness focusing your attention on something intentionally to remember it better. Essentially, it means **being aware of the values and behaviors we want to adopt or avoid**.

For example, through heedfulness we might realize we often **say upsetting or critical things to others**. Despite heedfulness, if we're not mindful of our value to **avoid harming others with our words**, we might keep doing it. By **cultivating mindfulness**, we **remember our values** during stressful times and change our behavior accordingly.

Reflect on this:

You desperately want to spend your savings on a new gadget you don't really need. How will you apply mindfulness to this situation?

Awareness

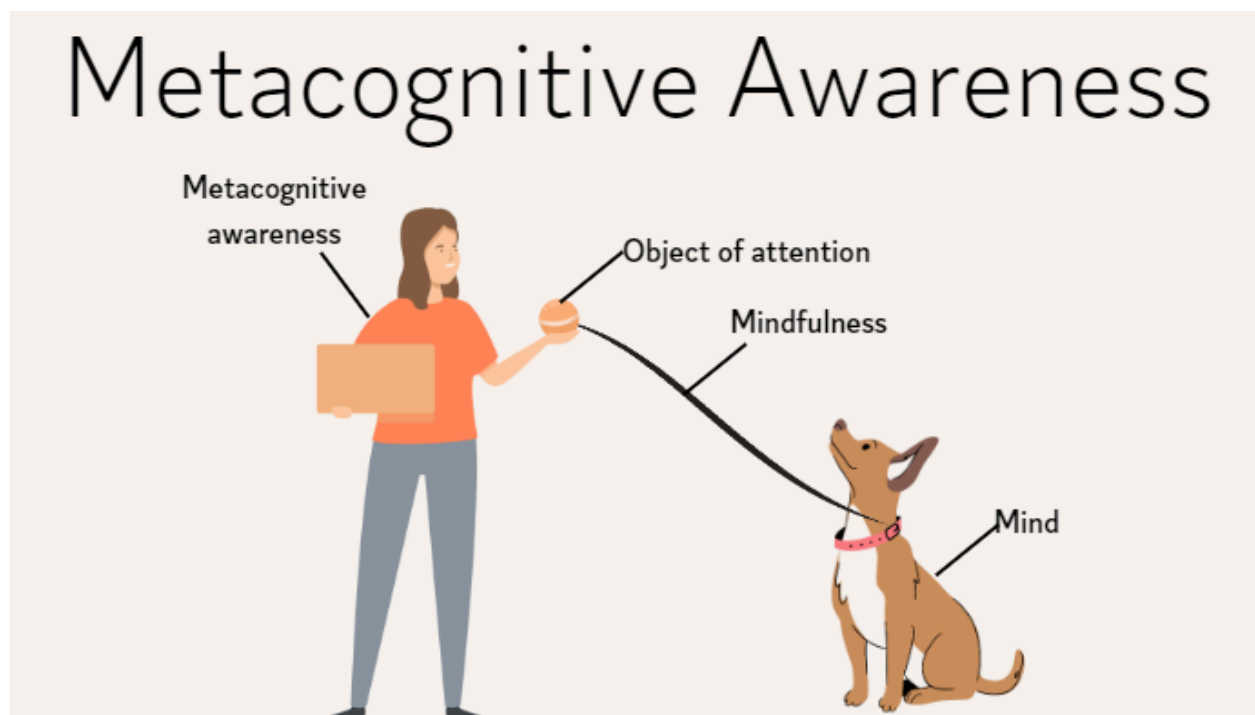
Awareness is being conscious of our thoughts and actions in the present moment. If we are not aware of how we speak or behave in the present moment, we can cause harm to ourselves and others even if we are heedful and mindful.

For example, if we realize we can harm others with our words (heedfulness) and want to avoid doing so (mindfulness), we might still cause harm if we're not aware of what we're saying in the moment. The same goes for our actions. Even with heedfulness and mindfulness, we can still harm ourselves and others if we're not aware of what we're doing right now.

Reflect on this:

You are participating in a team activity and notice that you are suddenly becoming overly aggressive and competitive. How will you apply awareness here?

Attention Stability and Metacognitive Awareness



The significance of **attention stability** can be understood through the concept of **metacognitive awareness**, which involves **being aware of where our attention is at any given moment**. Imagine your mind is like a playful puppy. Just like a puppy that runs around, our mind tends to wander, jumping from one thought to another. This can create problems, especially when we need to focus on studying or working, and our mind is instead worrying about the future or thinking about the past.

In this metaphor, the puppy is on a leash, and its owner holds a ball in her hand. The ball represents our object of attention—what we are trying to focus on. The leash is like our capacity for mindfulness or attention, helping us keep our focus on the ball. When the puppy begins to roam or move away from the owner, she recognizes this and calls the puppy back, reminding it to stay focused on the ball.

Similarly, when our mind starts to wander, we need metacognition (also called introspective awareness) to recognize when we have drifted away from our focus. By being aware of our wandering mind, we can gently bring our attention back to the task at hand. This practice helps us **maintain attention stability**, ensuring that we **stay focused and aligned with our goals and values**.

Ethical mindfulness combines heedfulness, mindfulness, and awareness to help us act in ways that are consistent with our values, even when our mind tries to wander. By practicing attention stability, we can improve our ability to stay focused, make better decisions, and avoid actions that might harm ourselves or others.

Quiz Summary

The quizzes are designed to check understanding of ethical mindfulness in real-life situations. They include scenario-based multiple-choice questions and simple reflection tasks. Students identify correct responses when dealing with emotions, values, attention wandering, and the three components of ethical mindfulness (heedfulness, mindfulness, and awareness). These help learners apply concepts rather than just memorize them.

Video Summary

The videos provide guided demonstrations of ethical mindfulness in practice. They show how to stay calm, focus attention, and respond wisely in daily situations. Some videos include mindfulness in communication and attention stability exercises, helping students observe and practice how to bring their focus back when the mind wanders.



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Skill 3: Emotional Awareness

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define emotional awareness
- Explain the importance of emotional awareness
- Identify afflictive and beneficial mental states
- Identify the nature of your thoughts
- Create space between speech and action to have greater mental balance and be less reactive
- Apply relevant tools to practice calmness.

What is Emotional Awareness? Why is it important?

Emotional Awareness is the ability to be aware of our mental experiences at each moment and differentiate between beneficial and potentially harmful mental states.

When someone asks how you're feeling, no matter what's going on, you might say something like, "I'm fine." But is it possible to always feel fine?

When we don't observe, accept and manage how we feel, it might be overwhelming or we might stay stuck in the high zone or the low zone for a long time. This can impact our personal life and professional life and our relationships with others. This is why Emotional Awareness is an essential skill.

Being Emotionally Aware means we are able to observe our thoughts, feelings, emotions, and sensations with awareness as they arise in the mind.

This ability really helps when we need to differentiate between potentially beneficial and harmful states.

Harmful mental states distort reality and can lead to problems like prejudice or hatred. While, beneficial mental states are attitudes and perspectives that lead us toward happiness and away from suffering.

Emotional Awareness allows us to be less reactive and more **resilient**. When we are able to make proper assessments of our mental states we can then **follow up with wise and conscious responses**.

For example, both scientific research and common sense suggest that **increasing lack of satisfaction, resentment, and stinginess** lead to less happiness and poorer relations. An **increase in gratitude, forgiveness, and generosity**, on the other hand, lead to greater happiness and better relations with others.

Emotional Awareness doesn't mean ignoring our thoughts or emotions. It's using awareness to:

- Observe our mental states with less **attachment**
- Investigate whether our **thoughts and feelings** are permanent or temporary
- and to create more space between our thoughts, emotions and speech or actions so that we can be less **reactive**

By doing this, we are able to become aware of the mental states and habits we wish to grow stronger and which mental states we want to weaken or transform.

Harmful and Beneficial Mental States

Like we discussed in the previous section, Emotional Awareness is the ability to be aware of our mental experiences at each moment and differentiate between beneficial and potentially harmful mental states.

Beneficial mental state: Beneficial mental states are the attitudes, emotions and perspectives that lead us to happiness and away from suffering. For example, studies suggest that having more gratitude and forgiveness in our lives lead to more happiness and better relationships with others.

Harmful mental states: Harmful mental states distort reality and lead to suffering for ourselves and others. For example, mental states like anger, resentment, **jealousy** can lead to **bitterness, unhappiness** and poorer **relationships with others**.

Spark to Forest Fire

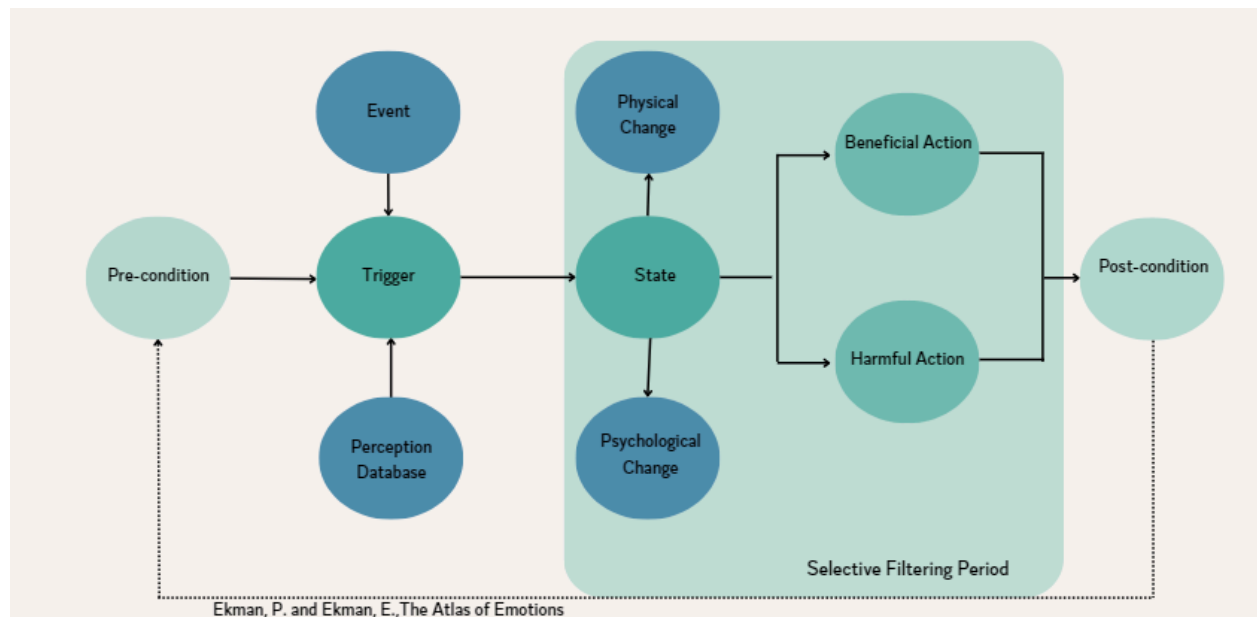
When we are **emotionally aware**, we can tell the difference between helpful and harmful thoughts by noticing them more clearly in the present moment. But how does this help us in our daily lives?

Imagine you have a difficult conversation with your boss/teacher that upsets you first thing in the morning. Without emotional awareness, it would be hard to recover and continue with your day. You might keep thinking about the conversation all day and struggle to focus on your work. By the end of the day, you could be angry at your boss for/teacher the conversation, angry at yourself for not finishing your work, and you might take all this anger and frustration home. When you get home, even a small question or comment from a family member could **irritate** you, leading you to be **rude** to them. This shows how one small situation at work can affect other parts of your life.

Think of this chain reaction like a small spark growing into a forest fire. It starts as a tiny, easily manageable spark, but once it becomes a large fire, it's much harder to control and can cause a big damage.

This kind of **thought chain** happens so quickly that we often don't realize it's happening. An angry outburst might be the result of a chain of thoughts that got out of control after a moment of **frustration**. This is a natural process in your mind and body, but you can learn how to take control and stop these tiny sparks before they turn into a mental and **emotional wildfire**.

Spark to Forest Fire



In this section, we'll explore a **helpful psychological model** that explains how a small spark can turn into a **wildfire of emotions**. While this model isn't a **perfect reflection of reality**, it can help us understand our experiences better and develop greater **emotional awareness**.

This model is inspired by the Atlas of Emotions by Paul and Eve Ekman.

Precondition

Every experience starts with a precondition, which is the state of your body and mind before anything happens.

Imagine waking up late **feeling tired and stressed** because you didn't get enough sleep. This tiredness is your precondition.

Event

Next, an event happens. This could be something external, like someone saying something to you, or internal, like a thought or physical sensation.

Since you already woke up late, you are running late for college/work and you are hurrying, you spill tea all over yourself.

Perception Database

Every event is filtered through your perception database, which is influenced by your past experiences and **personal history**. This means that each person reacts to events in their own unique way.

Because you've had stressful mornings before, spilling tea might **trigger memories** of similar situations where you were rushed and upset.

Trigger (The Spark)

The combination of your precondition, the event, and your perception creates a trigger, or spark, which causes an **automatic emotional response**.

The tea spilling incident triggers feelings of frustration and stress, making you feel even more irritated and **overwhelmed**.

Emotional Response

This trigger leads to an emotional response, which can include physical reactions like **sweating** or **trembling**, and mental changes like feelings of anger or **anxiety**.

After spilling your tea, you might feel your heart race, and have thoughts like, "I need to change, but I'm already late!" or "why does this always happen to me" or "Why can't I ever be on time" **flood your mind**.

Action (Beneficial or Harmful):

Your emotional state then leads to an action, which can be either beneficial or harmful. Beneficial actions lead to well-being, while harmful actions cause more **suffering**.

If you let your frustration control you, you will leave home in a **bad mood** and might have an **argument** with a classmate or have problems focusing during the day. Instead, you could take some minutes to **regulate your emotions** and focus on leaving home for the day.

Selective Filtering (Putting Out the Spark):

Even though it might feel like we automatically jump from emotion to action, there's a moment where we can choose how to respond. This is called selective filtering, where we decide whether to act in a beneficial or harmful way.

After spilling the tea, you pause and use tools like **grounding** or **resourcing** to **regulate yourself**, change into a fresh pair of clothes and move on with your day instead of letting one event ruin your mood. This is where skills like emotional awareness and **staying calm** (**equanimity**) help.

Do apply this model to your daily experiences and note at what point you choose to put out the spark!

Video (Emotional Awareness Demo)

A short video showing how a person notices their emotions, pauses, and responds calmly instead of reacting quickly. It demonstrates simple real-life situations like stress or anger and how to stay aware and calm.

Quiz (Emotional Awareness Quiz)

A set of simple scenario-based questions where the learner chooses the best emotional response. It checks understanding of emotions, reactions, and how to handle situations in a calm and balanced way.



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Skill 4: Self Compassion

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define self compassion
- Identify the different **thinking traps** and how they impact well being
- Recognize the importance of self compassion
- Examine if you practice self compassion
- Describe the three steps to **cultivate compassion**.
- Analyze how **suffering and happiness depend on our thoughts and emotions** rather than external situations
- Practice tools to develop greater self-compassion

What is Self-compassion

Self-compassion is about **recognizing our own worth, understanding what truly makes us happy or unhappy, and finding ways to improve our well-being.**

But it is always easy to be **compassionate towards ourselves**? Something that often gets in the way of practicing self compassion is thinking traps?

Thinking traps, or **cognitive distortions**, are ways our mind can trick us into believing things that aren't true. For example, you might think, "I'm not good enough" or "I always mess up," even when there's evidence that these thoughts aren't true. Our brain uses these thinking traps to protect us, but they often end up making us feel worse and block our path to true happiness.

To overcome these thinking traps, it's important to approach **self-reflection** with strength and **resilience**, so we can see past these distortions and focus on what will truly bring us happiness

and well-being. In the next section, we will discuss the common thinking traps and how we can move past them.

Thinking traps

Thinking traps are **harmful mental states** that **twist how we see reality**.

While our brain is designed to help us survive and thrive, it can sometimes make us see things incorrectly.

These distortions can affect how we feel, think, and even sense things around us.

Which of these lines do you think is longer?

<image 1>



<Image 2>



While many people might think the top line is longer, both these lines are the same length. Even if we measure these lines ourselves, the top line will still appear longer to us because it's **a persistent perceptual distortion**.

Thinking Trap 1: **Hedonic Treadmill**

The Hedonic Treadmill is a thinking trap where we keep **chasing things like money, status, pleasure, and praise, but never feel fully satisfied**. It's like running on a treadmill—you keep moving but never really get anywhere. For example, you might think, "If I just get that promotion, I'll be happy," but once you get it, you soon start wanting something else.

To step off the Hedonic Treadmill, it's important to practice **realism**, **contentment**, and **appreciation**. This doesn't mean you shouldn't aim for more in life, but it's about being aware of

what truly brings happiness and what doesn't. **Work towards your goals**, but also learn to appreciate what you have in the present moment.

For example, instead of always wanting the latest gadget, you can find **contentment** in the things you already own. By doing this, you can avoid the endless cycle of wanting more and more, which often leads to **frustration** rather than happiness.

Thinking Trap 2: **Unrealistic Expectations**

In our society, we often **see the lives of the rich, famous, beautiful, and talented as the ultimate success**. We are surrounded by images and stories of these “successful” people, making us believe that we need to be like them to be truly happy. This can make us chase after wealth, status, praise, and pleasure, while also **fearing things like financial loss, insignificance, blame, and pain**.

This belief that we need to live up to these high standards is a thinking trap called **Unrealistic Expectations**. It distorts our reality and often leads to disappointment and unhappiness. For example, you might think, “If I don’t have a lot of money or a perfect body, I won’t be happy.” But this kind of thinking only leads you towards more stress and suffering.

How to fix this?

We can start by examining our unrealistic expectations and understanding why we have them. For instance, ask yourself, “Why do I feel the need to be like these celebrities? What is really making me feel this way?” By shifting to a more caring and realistic view of yourself and others, you can focus on what truly matters, like your health, relationships, and personal growth.

We need to set goals without adding expectations that harm our well-being.

For example, instead of aiming to be like someone else, **set goals that are meaningful to you and that align with your values**. This helps you **stay grounded and satisfied**, rather than constantly chasing after something that might not even bring true happiness.

Unrealistic Expectations activity

Over the next one week, notice how you talk to yourself. Everytime you feel the pressure within yourself to achieve something, or to do something a certain way, ask yourself “is this an **aspiration or an expectation**” and note down how you feel. Alternatively, you can also use the following questions to reflect towards the end of the activity:

1. What are the **sensations you felt in your body** when you felt the pressure to achieve a certain goal?
2. Was that **pressure external or internal**?
3. Did you notice a shift when you reflected on whether your **thought was an aspiration or an expectation**?

Read each scenario below and decide whether it represents a **realistic expectation** (**a goal that is achievable and considers your abilities and circumstances**) or an unrealistic expectation (a goal that is too demanding or not achievable given the circumstances). Examine the following scenarios.

Scenarios:

1. You expect to learn a **new language fluently** in just one month without any prior experience.
2. You plan to save a small portion of your income each month to eventually **buy a new laptop within a year**.
3. You expect to **never make mistakes at work**, even though you're still learning the job.
4. You aim to **improve your grades** by dedicating an extra hour each day to study.
5. You expect to be in **perfect physical shape** after just one week of starting a new exercise routine.
6. You expect to **balance a full-time job, school, and social life perfectly** without ever feeling stressed or tired.
7. You plan to **improve your public speaking skills** by practicing in front of a small group of friends before presenting to a larger audience.

Types of Unrealistic Expectations

Superiority Bias

~~Superiority Bias~~ Superiority Bias is when we think we are better, more unique, or overly optimistic about ourselves. This might seem harmless, but it can actually lead to problems like **self-hatred** or **low self-esteem** when reality doesn't match the way we view ourselves.

For example, you might think **you're always right and others are wrong**, but when things don't go your way, it can **make you feel really down**.

Inferiority Bias

Inferiority Bias happens when we **underestimate our abilities or worth**. This can make us set goals that are too hard to prove ourselves or set goals that are too easy because we don't believe we can do better.

For example, you might avoid trying new things because you're convinced you'll fail, or you might push yourself too hard, **leading to burnout**. **Realistic expectations** mean **setting goals that are neither too high nor too low but match what we can realistically achieve**.

Perfectionism

Perfectionism is when we expect ourselves (or others) to be perfect all the time. When we make even small mistakes, we **judge ourselves harshly**, leading to **disappointment** and **frustration**. It can also make us **overly critical of others** when they don't meet our unrealistic standards.

For example, if you expect to get perfect grades all the time, a single low mark can be very disappointing, even though it's a **normal part of learning**. Perfectionism can **strain our relationships and make life more stressful**.

In summary, having unrealistic expectations—whether **thinking too highly or too poorly of ourselves**—can lead to **unnecessary stress** and **dissatisfaction**. By recognizing these biases, we can work towards setting more balanced and achievable goals, improving our overall well-being and relationships.

Why is Self-compassion important?

Imagine you're having a tough day where everything **feels overwhelming** and stressful. What if, instead of letting the stress take over, you **paused and thought about how you're feeling?** Ask yourself: Is this **feeling helping or hurting** me? If it's hurting, what's causing it? Often, our thoughts and emotions come from a desire to avoid suffering and find happiness. But what's stopping us from being **truly happy?**

Sometimes, we mistakenly believe that **material things or short-term pleasures** will make us happy, but they only bring **temporary satisfaction**. Constantly chasing money, pleasure, praise, or status can actually make us feel worse, not better. Similarly, worrying too much about losing these things or feeling like you're not good enough can increase your stress and unhappiness. Unrealistic expectations can add pressure and make you feel bad about yourself when you don't meet them.

Ask yourself: Could your suffering be linked to expecting too much from yourself? Are you focusing too much on external things for happiness instead of looking inward?

Practicing self-compassion means realizing that you can **change by understanding yourself better, developing new skills, and adopting positive attitudes**. The goal of self-compassion is to **build confidence in your ability** to achieve **lasting happiness, resilience, and inner peace**. By **being kinder** and more **compassionate to yourself**, you lay the foundation to show more **forgiveness, gratitude, empathy, and compassion to others**.

Self-compassion is understanding your own worth, knowing what makes you happy or unhappy, and finding ways to improve your well-being.

Let us now see how compassionate we are to ourselves.

Do you practice Self-Compassion?

Write a letter to a friend activity

Write a letter to a friend who is going through a difficult time. In this letter, give your friend your support and include **words of encouragement to help** him/her through this difficult time.

Now, read this letter out aloud to yourself and reflect on the following questions:

1. How did that message make you feel?
2. Do you use similar words of encouragement and support when you are going through a difficult time? If not, why?

Three steps to Cultivate Compassion

Most of us find it easier to be compassionate towards others than ourselves. However, it is important to practice self-compassion for greater mental well-being. We know that we can't pour out of an empty cup, so, if we want to help others, we should first work on ourselves. How do we cultivate self-compassion? Here are three steps we can follow:

1. Remind yourself of that **you have value regardless of your external circumstances**
2. Understand and define what happiness means to you
3. Examine your way of thinking and acting and identify where you need to change.

Eight Worldly concerns

We all want to be happy, but the problem is with our understanding of what might bring us true happiness. For some of us it might be **material wealth**, while others might think a **happy relationship** or a **new career** might bring us lasting happiness, but does that really happen?

External sources do not lead to happiness because they are not permanent and not in our sole control. Instead, we need to shift our focus to internal qualities because they are under our control and can bring us genuine, lasting happiness.

One useful model for helping us think of the things we strive for and try to avoid that often lead to harmful mental states is the Eight Worldly Concerns. Our society often tells us that certain external things will bring happiness. Wealth, pleasure, praise or status are not inherently bad, and there is no harm in seeking them. While they definitely play a role in our happiness and well-being, what we need to determine is how much of a role they should play.

In the next section, we will discuss the eight worldly concerns and how they impact us.

Thinking Traps

Thinking Trap	Explanation
Status vs Insignificance	When we are too focused on these two worldly concerns, we want to be known as someone important and powerful and constantly strive for roles, positions, or titles that are considered valuable by society. Conversely, we fear losing that status and are afraid of not having an important role or being overlooked by our peers or society.
Financial loss vs Financial gain	When caught up in these two worldly concerns, we think money and material possessions will bring us lasting happiness but we constantly strive for bigger and better things, forgetting to be grateful for and enjoy what we have in that moment. On the other hand, fearing the loss of money or possessions can cause us to hoard them and feel disappointed or upset if we don't get or lose them.
Blame vs Praise	When we get caught by these two worldly concerns we seek people's compliments and approval of what we do or say and feel disappointed/ worthless when someone criticizes or disapproves of us, irrespective of

	whether there may be some truth to their criticism.
Pain vs Pleasure	When too focused on these two worldly concerns, we're constantly striving for pleasure through external means and moving from one thing to another without finding true happiness. Or, the fear of physical pain makes us constantly miserable. The more we focus on a source of real or potential pain, the more suffering it causes us.

Video 1: Understanding Self-CompassionThis video explains what self-compassion means and how being kind to ourselves helps improve emotional well-being. It shows how understanding our thoughts and feelings can reduce stress and support a healthier mindset.

Video 2: Overcoming Thinking TrapsThis video introduces common thinking traps like unrealistic expectations and the hedonic treadmill. It explains how these mental patterns affect our happiness and gives simple ideas on how to recognize and manage them.

Quiz: Self-Compassion CheckThis quiz helps students check their understanding of self-compassion and thinking traps. It includes simple scenario-based questions where learners identify realistic vs unrealistic expectations and recognize self-compassion practices.



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Skill 5: Impartiality and Common Humanity

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define Bias
- Identify what all human beings have in common
- Explain impartiality and common humanity
- Identify explicit and implicit bias and techniques to weaken them
- Practice tools to cultivate impartiality

What do you understand by bias?

It's natural for us to have biases, even if we're not always aware of them. Biases help us quickly understand the world by categorizing people and things based on our experiences, biology, and culture. This ability to quickly label and categorize has been helpful for survival. For example, if we see a large, growling animal, we instantly recognize it as dangerous and avoid it, which could save our lives.

However, while categorizing can be useful, it becomes a problem when we start to see these categories as fixed and unchanging. This can lead us to put people into groups—like "those who are like me" (in-group) and "those who are not like me" (out-group).

In-group bias is a thinking trap that can lead to stereotypes and the belief that certain groups have a fixed nature (essentialism). For example, we might think that all people of a certain race or religion are the same. But it's important to remember that these categories are just labels and don't define a person's true nature.

If we're not careful, these categories can make us view out-groups as less human or even evil, which can justify negative behaviors like discrimination, unfair treatment, or violence. This thinking trap prevents us from seeing the common humanity we all share.

Stereotype

A **stereotype** is a fixed idea or image that people often have about a certain type of person or thing. For example, if the words "old lady," "bully," "cowboy," or "terrorist" make you instantly think of a certain type of person, then these ideas have become stereotypes for you.

Stereotypes can be based on things like nationality, religion, gender, race, or age. They can be both positive and negative.

For instance, a positive stereotype might be, "People from Country Y are good students" or "Families in Country Z are great hosts." But negative stereotypes can lead to false beliefs and even result in prejudice or discrimination.

Prejudice

Prejudice is a negative attitude or feeling towards someone or a group of people, usually formed without knowing them personally. When we have prejudiced attitudes, we tend to judge everyone in that group the same way, instead of seeing each person as unique.

For example, if someone has a prejudice against a particular nationality, they might assume that everyone from that country is rude or unfriendly, even though they've never met anyone from there.

Prejudice stops us from learning about people who are different from us. Because of this, we can miss out on meaningful relationships and conversations that could have been really rewarding.

Understanding Impartiality and Common Humanity

Common humanity means focusing on what all people have in common, like our shared desire for happiness and to avoid suffering.

Impartiality is about reducing the strong biases that make us favor one group over another. It doesn't mean we stop caring about our loved ones or treat everyone exactly the same. Instead, it means learning to value and appreciate people who are outside our usual circles—like strangers or those in different groups—by recognizing our shared humanity.

Think of the sun: it shines its light on everyone without favoring one person or group, yet it naturally shines brighter on those who are closer. Similarly, we often feel more compassion and kindness toward those who are close to us, but this doesn't have to create a bias that makes us think they deserve more happiness than others.

Even though it's natural to feel more connected to people we know well, this doesn't mean we can't also care about others. Impartiality is about broadening our compassion to include everyone, not just those closest to us.

It's normal for impartiality to be challenging because we naturally form groups and biases. But with practice, we can learn to extend our feelings of common humanity to more people, treating them with the same kindness and respect we give to those we know well.

Let's now try one activity

Who are you Activity

Follow these instructions to do this activity:

1. Get a piece of paper and a pen.
2. Write down "Who Are You" in the middle.
3. Select Start Timer.
4. Create a mind map around this question with different words that come to mind for 90 seconds.
5. Once the timer is up, take a few minutes to think about the question and your responses.
6. When you're ready, restart the timer by selecting Start Timer.
7. Do the activity again without using any labels or repeating the words used before.

Reflective questions

1. What insights emerged for you during this activity?
2. What were the differences in your answers between the two rounds?
3. What does this activity reveal about our identities?
4. How many identities do you think we have?
5. How many of our identities are seen by someone when they first meet us?
6. What might this activity show us about labels?

Quiz (Skill 5 – Impartiality and Common Humanity)

The quiz is designed to check whether learners understand key ideas like bias, stereotypes, prejudice, and impartiality. It uses short multiple-choice questions and reflection-based questions. Learners choose the most appropriate answers based on real-life scenarios, helping them test how they would respond in biased or fair situations. The goal is to strengthen understanding and encourage self-reflection on personal thinking patterns.

Video 1 – Impartiality in Daily Life

This video shows real-life situations where people may react with bias or fairness. It demonstrates how individuals can pause, reflect, and respond with impartiality instead of judging quickly. The purpose is to help learners visually understand how bias appears in everyday interactions and how choosing a fair response improves relationships and decision-making.

Video 2 – Common Humanity Visualization

This video is a guided visual experience that helps learners feel connected to all people. It highlights that everyone shares similar human experiences like happiness, stress, and emotions. The aim is to develop empathy and reduce "us vs them" thinking by helping learners emotionally connect with others beyond labels or groups.



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Skill 6: Forgiveness and Gratitude

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define forgiveness
- List strategies to practice forgiveness.
- Identify thinking traps to forgiveness.
- Define gratitude
- List strategies to cultivate gratitude
- Apply the tools to practice forgiveness and gratitude

What is forgiveness?

Forgiveness means letting go of anger and resentment towards someone who has hurt us and replacing those negative feelings with more positive and helpful ones.

Forgiving can be tough, but it's important for our mental and emotional health and our relationships with others. Many people think that forgiving someone means forgetting what they did, accepting it, or saying it was okay—but that's not true. Forgiveness doesn't mean you're weak; it actually shows strength.

When we forgive, we free ourselves from the burden of negative emotions and allow room for peace and well-being. For example, if a friend betrays your trust, forgiving them doesn't mean you have to forget what happened or act like it didn't hurt. Instead, it means choosing not to let anger control you and focusing on your own peace of mind. Forgiving someone isn't something that happens overnight, but there are tools and practices that can help make it easier over time.

In the next section we discuss the strategies to cultivate forgiveness and analyze what stops us from practicing forgiveness.

Strategies to cultivate forgiveness

Understand Causes and Conditions

When someone harms us, we often think that the person alone is to blame for what they did. We forget that there are many factors that might have led to their actions, like their upbringing, friends, genetics, social status, education, or current life situations. For example, if someone yells at you, it might be because they are stressed from work or dealing with personal issues, not because they are a bad person. Interestingly, when we make mistakes, we usually blame the situation rather than our own character. For example, if you miss a deadline, you might blame being too busy, rather than thinking you're irresponsible.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking traps of reductive thinking and fatal attribution error. **Reductive thinking** is when we believe something happened due to just one reason, instead of recognizing the many factors involved. **Fatal attribution error** is when we blame someone's behavior on their personality or character, rather than considering external factors like their environment or past experiences.

For instance, if a coworker is rude to you, instead of thinking they are just a rude person (fatal attribution error), consider that they might be under a lot of stress or have had a bad day. By understanding the causes and conditions that influence people's actions, it becomes easier to forgive and let go of resentment. This helps us move towards greater emotional peace and healthier relationships.

Focus on Common Humanity

When we're angry or resentful towards someone, it's easy to think of them as completely different from us. We might say, "They're nothing like me," which makes it easier to stay angry. But if we focus on how we're similar, it can help reduce our anger. For example, if a friend lets you down, instead of thinking, "They don't care about me," you might remember times when you've made mistakes too. This makes it easier to see them as a human being who's not perfect, just like you.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking trap of **ignoring our shared humanity**. When we realize that others are just as human and imperfect as we are, we stop holding them to impossible standards. For example, if a colleague does a bad job on a project, instead of seeing them as incompetent, you might think about how you've also made mistakes under pressure. Recognizing that we all have flaws makes it easier to forgive others and let go of resentment.

By focusing on what we share as human beings—like making mistakes, having bad days, or dealing with stress—we can find it easier to forgive and build stronger, more compassionate relationships.

Cultivate Gratitude

When we're trying to forgive someone, cultivating gratitude means thinking about the positive things that person may have done for us, even if they've also hurt us. For some, this might be difficult, and that's okay. In such cases, we can instead focus on how the tough experience taught us something valuable or helped us grow.

For example, if a friend betrayed your trust, it might be hard to think of anything positive about them. But you could try to appreciate how the experience made you stronger or more careful in choosing your friends.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking trap of **negativity bias**, where we focus only on the bad things that happened. Instead of dwelling on the hurt, we can shift our focus to the positive aspects of our lives that help us move past anger and resentment. For example, after a difficult breakup, instead of only remembering the pain, you might focus on how it helped you learn more about yourself and what you truly want in a relationship.

By practicing gratitude, we can find it easier to let go of negative feelings and move towards forgiveness, allowing us to heal and grow from difficult experiences.

Activity

Pick one incident from your past where you feel like someone wronged you. Do not pick a traumatic memory, pick something that you can easily work with.

Think of one strategy you think you can apply to try and forgive this person. It is fine even if you think none of these strategies might work, but write about that event and explore if these strategies can help. After completing the activity, reflect on the following questions:

1. How did you feel while reliving that event?
2. Do you think any of these strategies will help you?
3. Did your perspective shift after you attempted to practice forgiveness?

Forgiveness and gratitude are connected.

Gratitude is the recognition of the benefits one receives from others, be it one or more people, other aspects of nature, or a supernatural being or force.

Gratitude recognizes the benefits one receives from others, be it one or more people, other aspects of nature, or a supernatural being or force. Gratitude can be an emotion or trait. As an emotion, it's a feeling of thankfulness and appreciation. As a trait, it refers to a person's disposition toward gratitude.

A person with greater trait-gratitude would experience it more easily and frequently.

In the next section, we discuss the strategies to cultivate gratitude

Strategies to cultivate gratitude

Focus on What One Has Received

This strategy is about appreciating the things our friends and loved ones do for us every day, even if we sometimes take them for granted.

For example, your friend might always listen to you when you're upset, or your partner might help with chores at home. Even if someone didn't do something specifically for you, you can still be thankful for how it benefits you.

Focus on What Others Have Not Done

We usually think of gratitude in terms of what others do for us, but we can also be grateful for what they don't do.

For example, when you're driving or riding, you rely on others to follow the rules of the road. If they drive safely, it prevents accidents, which is something to be thankful for, even though it's easy to overlook.

Focus on What One Has Learned Through the Experience

Even negative experiences can teach us valuable lessons. For example, going through a breakup might be painful, but it could help you understand what you need in a relationship. Losing a job might open the door to better opportunities.

These tough experiences can help us grow stronger and more resilient, a concept known as "post-traumatic growth." Sometimes, the lesson is simply learning what not to do, which is also important.

Slide 4

Engage in Naikan Practice

Naikan is a reflective practice where you focus on someone important in your life, like your mother, and ask yourself three questions:

1. What have I received from this person?
2. What have I given them in return?
3. What trouble have I caused them?

We don't focus on the trouble they caused us, because our minds naturally lean towards negativity. This practice helps us appreciate the positive impact others have had on our lives. We'll explore this practice more deeply later in the course.

Recognize Interdependence

We often think we're mostly independent, but in reality, we rely on countless others every day. For example, the food you eat involves farmers, truck drivers, grocery store workers, and many more people.

Recognizing how connected we are to others helps us see their actions as acts of kindness. This mindset helps us avoid the thinking trap of believing we're completely self-sufficient when, in fact, we depend on many people to live the way we do.

These strategies help us cultivate gratitude by focusing on the positive aspects of our relationships and experiences, even in situations that might not seem positive at first. By practicing these approaches, we can foster a greater sense of appreciation and well-being in our daily lives.

Naikan Practice

In this section we will discuss the Naikan practice in detail. The Naikan practice which originated in Japan translates to "looking inside" or "introspection." This is a very useful practice for cultivating gratitude and forgiveness.

During the Naikan practice, ask yourself these three questions about a person in your life:

1. What have I received from this person?
2. What have I given this person in return?
3. What troubles have I caused this person?

While practicing this technique, it is important to ensure that you don't think about any troubles this person may have caused you. That's because this is naturally what we think about due to our negativity bias and what we are trying to do now is overcome negative thought patterns that get in the way of your well-being and healthy relationships.

Follow the following steps to do the Naikan Activity and do share your reflections in the text box below. Alternatively, you can also download the activity handout.

1. Bring to mind someone from your life on whom you would like to do Naikan practice. (If this is a person you have known for more than a year, you may wish to choose a specific time period to start with, such as the first year or few years you knew this person, and then continue from there the next time you do this practice.)
2. List all the things you received from this person, being specific.

3. List all the things you have given this person in return.
4. List anything you did that may have caused trouble for this person.

Questions for reflection

1. What thoughts, emotions and sensations arise in your body and mind from doing this practice?
2. When you finish writing, end with bringing to mind a resource or focus on the contact of your body with a surface, object or another body part, and allow yourself to notice any neutral or pleasant sensations that arise in your body.
3. Did you gain any insights from this practice?

Videos (Short Explanation)

1) Understanding Forgiveness

Explains what forgiveness really means, clears common myths, and shows how letting go of anger supports emotional healing.

2) Practicing Empathy in Daily Life Demonstrates how seeing others with empathy and recognizing shared humanity helps reduce resentment and conflict.

3) Power of Gratitude in Life Shows how practicing gratitude in small daily moments improves mental well-being and relationships.

4) Practicing Gratitude Daily (Guided) A simple guided practice that teaches learners how to reflect, notice positives, and build a daily gratitude habit.

Quizzes (Short Explanation)

1) Forgiveness Reflection Quiz Learners reflect on a past incident and answer questions to see if their perspective changed after applying forgiveness strategies.

2) Naikan Reflection Quiz Learners answer questions after the Naikan activity to observe their thoughts, emotions, body sensations, and insights gained from the practice.



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Skill 7:Empathic Concern

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define Empathy and differentiate it from sympathy
- Identify the two types of empathy: affective and cognitive empathy.
- Identify thinking traps against empathy.
- Recognize the significance of Empathic Concern
- Explain empathic distress and the strategies to reduce it
- Apply strategies to cultivate sympathetic joy

What Does Empathy mean?

Empathy is the ability to understand and share the feelings, thoughts, and motivations of someone else. But it's important to ask ourselves if our empathy is always reasonable or if just feeling empathy is enough.

Empathy comes naturally to us because of something called **“emotional contagion.”** This is when emotions and behaviors automatically spread from one person to another. For example, when you see someone yawn, you might feel like yawning too. Or if someone in a room is very anxious, their anxiety can make everyone else feel tense as well.

From an evolutionary perspective, **emotional contagion** is helpful because it allows us to react to danger quickly. For instance, if you see someone suddenly look scared and start running, your instinct might be to run too, even if you don't know why. This quick reaction can keep us safe.

Emotional contagion can happen through things like facial expressions, body language, and tone of voice. While it's not the same as full empathy, emotional contagion shows that the roots of empathy are deeply embedded in our nature and history.

Next, we'll explore the two types of empathy.

Affective and Cognitive Empathy

Affective Empathy

Affective empathy is when we emotionally connect with someone else's feelings. For example, if a friend is feeling very sad, you might feel sad too, as if you're sharing their pain. Similarly, if a loved one has something great happen to them, you might feel happy just because they are happy.

Cognitive Empathy

Cognitive empathy is when we use our thinking skills to understand what someone else is going through, even if we don't feel their emotions ourselves. This is often called "putting yourself in someone else's shoes." For instance, if a coworker is stressed about a deadline, you might not feel stressed yourself, but you can understand why they are feeling that way by imagining yourself in their situation.

Both types of empathy help us connect with others, but in different ways—one through shared emotions, and the other through understanding.

Thinking traps to Empathy and strategies to overcome thinking traps

In-Group Bias	We naturally feel more empathy for people who are like us or part of our "in-group," such as friends or family. However, we may feel less empathy for people outside our group, like strangers or people we see as different. This bias can limit our empathy and harm our ability to connect with others. Example: You might feel deep sympathy for a friend who's going through a tough time but feel indifferent to a similar story you heard about in the news.
One-Over-Many	Research shows that we tend to feel the most empathy when we see one person suffering, but as the number of people suffering increases, our empathy can decrease. This doesn't make sense because we should feel more empathy when more people are in need.

	Example: You might feel a strong urge to help when you hear about one child in need, but when you hear about a large group of children suffering, the emotional impact might be less.
Empathic Distress	Sometimes, we feel overwhelmed by others' suffering, leading to feelings of hopelessness or burnout. This can make us want to shut down or give up trying to help. Example: You might feel so overwhelmed by the scale of a global crisis that you feel powerless to make a difference and end up doing nothing.
Jealousy/Envy	When we see someone else experiencing something positive, especially if we see them as a rival, we might feel jealous or envious. This thinking trap can make us believe that someone else's success takes away from our own happiness. Example: If a coworker gets a promotion, you might feel envious and think that their success means you're less successful.

Remember Our Common Humanity	To overcome in-group bias, we can practice seeing everyone as part of the same human family. By recognizing that we're all connected and dependent on each other, we can extend our empathy beyond just those who are close to us. Example: Instead of only feeling empathy for people you know, you might remind yourself that everyone, even strangers, shares the same basic needs and feelings.
Use Cognitive Empathy	To address the one-over-many trap, we can use logic to realize that caring for many people in need is just as important, if not more so, than caring for one person. Cognitive empathy helps us understand others' situations without getting overwhelmed by emotions.

	Example: If you hear about a large group of people suffering, try to put yourself in their shoes and think about how you would feel in their situation, rather than just reacting emotionally.
Cultivate Self-Compassion	To manage empathic distress, we can practice self-compassion by taking care of our own emotional needs and building resilience. This helps us stay strong and continue to help others without getting overwhelmed. Example: If you're feeling burned out from helping others, take some time for self-care and remind yourself that it's okay to need a break.
Practice Sympathetic Joy	To overcome jealousy and envy, we can practice feeling joy for others' successes and good fortune. Recognizing that someone else's success doesn't take away from our own happiness can help us feel more connected and less isolated. Example: If a friend achieves something great, instead of feeling envious, try to genuinely celebrate their success and feel happy for them.

Empathy and Bias

Empathic distress happens when we become overwhelmed by someone else's suffering. This overwhelming feeling can lead to burnout, where we feel so drained and hopeless that we start to shut down emotionally. For example, if you're constantly exposed to stories of people in pain, you might start feeling so much sadness that you begin to feel numb and unable to help.

Empathic distress often occurs because our empathy is biased—we tend to feel more empathy for people who are like us or who we see as part of our group, while feeling less for those we consider "others." This narrow focus can make our empathy irrational and limited, leading to problems when we face situations that require broader understanding and action.

However, there's a way to overcome empathic distress by cultivating empathic concern. Unlike empathic distress, which is focused on our own emotional reaction to others' suffering, empathic concern is about genuinely caring for the needs of others without getting

overwhelmed. It allows us to respond to suffering with compassion and helpful actions, rather than feeling paralyzed by it.

To develop empathic concern, we need to expand our empathy beyond just those we relate to. By practicing seeing everyone as part of the same human family, we can broaden our perspective and make empathy a more effective tool for supporting compassion and ethical behavior.

Sympathetic Joy

Sympathetic joy is the ability to feel happiness for someone else's good fortune or success. Instead of feeling jealous or envious when others do well, we genuinely share in their joy and celebrate their achievements as if they were our own. This quality helps us build stronger, more positive relationships and contributes to our own happiness.

How to Cultivate Sympathetic Joy:

1. Practice Gratitude:

- Start by appreciating the good things in your own life. When you regularly practice gratitude for what you have, it becomes easier to feel joy for others without comparing yourself to them.
- **Example:** If a friend gets a promotion, instead of feeling envious, remind yourself of the good things in your own career and genuinely celebrate their success. Try to imagine the amount of hard work or struggle he/she would have put in to reach here which you might not be aware of just because he/she never discussed about that.

2. Reflect on Interdependence:

- Recognize that we are all interconnected and that others' success can benefit you, too. When someone else does well, it can create a positive impact on your community or group.
- **Example:** If a colleague wins an award, think about how their success brings recognition to your team, which can open up more opportunities for everyone including you

3. Practice tools for emotional regulation

- Several times we might feel negative emotions when we are emotionally dysregulated. Using tools like tracking, grounding or resourcing will help you feel regulated and think clearly.
- **Example:** When you notice a wave of envy, pause for a moment and track your sensations to see where you feel them in your body. You can then use grounding or resourcing to regulate your emotions and get back into the resilient zone.

Quiz (Learning Check)

Identify Empathy Types (Affective vs Cognitive)

Learners read small scenarios and decide whether the response shows feeling others' emotions (affective empathy) or understanding others' situations (cognitive empathy).

Identify Thinking Traps

Learners are given situations and asked to recognize which thinking trap is happening (in-group bias, one-over-many effect, empathic distress, jealousy/envy)

Empathic Concern vs Empathic DistressLearners choose the healthier response to suffering—whether the reaction shows emotional overwhelm (distress) or calm caring action (empathic concern).

Purpose of the Quiz:To check whether learners can correctly recognize empathy types, notice barriers to empathy, and choose compassionate responses.

Videos (Support Media)

Empathy Types Explanation VideoA short video with real-life examples explaining the difference between affective empathy and cognitive empathy.

Empathic Distress to Empathic Concern VideoDemonstrates how people become emotionally overwhelmed by others' suffering and how they can shift to calm, caring action.

Practicing Sympathetic Joy VideoA guided explanation showing how to feel happy for others' success instead of feeling jealousy or envy.

Purpose of the Videos:To visually demonstrate concepts and help learners understand how to apply empathy skills in real-life situations.

Skill 8: Compassion

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define compassion
- Identify thinking traps to compassion
- Recognize that compassion is not a weakness
- Explain the three necessary components of compassion
- Demonstrate techniques to practice compassion to different groups

What is Compassion? And Common Thinking traps to Compassion

In SEEK, we define compassion as the wish to ease the suffering of another rooted in care for their well-being and a degree of self-confidence.

However, something that often blocks our ability to practice compassion is falling into thinking traps.

Thinking traps, or cognitive distortions, are ways our mind can trick us into believing things that aren't true.

Thinking traps to Compassion

Compassion as Weakness	Many people mistakenly believe that being compassionate means being weak or allowing others to take advantage of you. However, true compassion often requires strength and standing firm against people or institutions when giving in would cause harm. For instance, standing up to someone who is being unfair can be an act of compassion,
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	both for yourself and others. Being a "pushover" or "doormat" is not genuine compassion; it may stem from harmful thinking traps like empathic distress, where we become overwhelmed by others' emotions.
Not Seeing Common Humanity	Sometimes we fail to see others' suffering because we don't recognize our shared humanity. Even if someone seems to have no problems, they likely experience difficulties that aren't seen to us, like emotional pain, financial worries, or health issues. By understanding that all humans suffer in some way, we can avoid the trap of overlooking others' suffering. For example, a classmate who always seems cheerful might be dealing with stress at home that we don't know about.
In-Group Bias	We naturally feel more compassion for people we know and like, but much less for strangers or those we dislike. This In-Group Bias prevents us from extending our compassion to everyone. For instance, we might go out of our way to help a friend in need, but ignore the struggles of someone we don't know or don't share a good relationship with. Overcoming this bias helps us develop a broader and more inclusive sense of compassion.
Powerlessness	When we feel powerless, we believe that our actions or thoughts can't make a difference, which can block our compassion. This trap makes us feel helpless and leads to apathy. For example, if you see news about a large-scale disaster such as earthquake or flood, you might feel like there's nothing you can do to help, and this feeling of powerlessness can prevent you from taking any action at all. Building confidence in our ability to make even small changes can help us overcome this trap and act with compassion.

	By recognizing and addressing these thinking traps, we can develop a stronger and more effective sense of compassion that isn't limited by bias, powerlessness, or misconceptions about what it means to be compassionate.
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Is compassion a Weakness?

Many people believe that showing compassion means we have to sacrifice our own needs or let others take advantage of us. However, compassion is not a sign of weakness. In fact, it's a powerful force that motivates us to ease the suffering of others while also strengthening us. Compassion can give us confidence, hope, and energy because it connects us to a deep sense of purpose and meaning.

Compassion as Strength: Compassion is about genuinely caring for the well-being of others, but it doesn't mean ignoring your own needs or allowing others to take advantage of you. For example, imagine a friend who constantly asks for favors without considering your needs. Compassion doesn't mean saying "yes" every time and neglecting your own well-being. Instead, true compassion might involve setting boundaries, so you can help them in a way that's sustainable for you both.

Compassion outside our in-group: Compassion isn't just for people we know and like—it should extend to everyone, including those outside our immediate circle. For example, if you see a stranger struggling with a heavy load, offering to help, even though you don't know them, is an act of extended compassion. This type of compassion recognizes that all humans have value, and we should care about their well-being, regardless of their relationship to us.

Compassion as a Motivation: It's important to remember that compassion is a motivation—it drives us to want to help others—but it doesn't tell us what the best action is in every situation. We need to combine compassion with critical inquiry and understanding. For example, if someone is struggling with a difficult decision, your compassion might motivate you to help, but critical inquiry will guide you to offer advice that's more logical, and supportive, rather than just telling them what to do.

Three Components of Compassion

Infographic

1) Noticing Suffering

It's often easy to see obvious forms of outward suffering, such as someone crying or bleeding from a wound. But people also suffer or have needs in ways that are less noticeable.

Example: A coworker might appear to be handling their workload well, but if you notice that they are increasingly withdrawn or seem distracted, they might be dealing with stress. Recognizing these less visible signs of suffering is the first step toward offering support.

2) Empathic Concern

Noticing suffering and the needs of others is not enough; we must feel that the sufferers deserve our compassion and care.

Example: If you see a stranger struggling to carry heavy bags, empathic concern is what makes you want to offer help, even though you don't know them personally. It's the feeling that everyone deserves kindness and help, regardless of who they are.

3) A Sense of Agency

Without confidence in our ability to act if needed, our compassion can become ineffective, leaving us feeling powerless and eventually apathetic due to empathic distress.

Example: If a friend is going through a tough time, your sense of agency might prompt you to offer a listening ear or practical help, like helping them with chores. Believing that your actions can help, even in small ways, helps you practice compassion.

Reflection

Reflect on a time when you needed to be compassionate towards others, but also had to consider your own needs. How did you balance the two?

Three levels of Compassion

Wishing Compassion

Say you learn about floods in another city. An example of **Wishing Compassion** would be, "I wish they were free from suffering." In this scenario you notice others are suffering and naturally wish for them to be free from harm and to be happy. At this level, you take no personal responsibility for alleviating the suffering of those you are impacted by the situation.

Example: Imagine you hear about floods in a city you don't live in. You might think, "I hope the people there are safe and that the situation gets better soon." While you genuinely wish for their well-being, you don't take any action beyond this thought.

Aspiring Compassion

The next level, **Aspiring Compassion**, includes more urgency, intensity, and some personal responsibility for reducing the suffering of others. You may think of small ways you could make the lives of those impacted by the earthquake easier. Like: "It'd be great for their suffering to end. Maybe I can send in a small donation or help with rescue work."

Example: After hearing about the floods, you feel moved to do more and think, "I really hope they get the help they need. Maybe I can donate to a relief fund or spread awareness on social media to encourage others to help."

Engaged Compassion

The third level is **Engaged Compassion**. At this level you feel great urgency to end the suffering of others and take on personal responsibility for doing all that you can to do so.

Perhaps you say, “They must feel better. I’m going to do whatever I can to help those suffering from the aftermath of the earthquake!”

Example: With Engaged Compassion, you might decide, “I need to do something to help those affected by the wildfire. I’m going to personally collect and send relief material, volunteer a local organization that is helping the victims, or even travel to the area to help with recovery efforts.”

Remember, it may not be possible to experience Engaged Compassion for all the suffering you see in the world. You need to ground your compassion for others in self-compassion and realistic expectations. It’s possible to experience engaged compassion for one cause and wishing compassion for another and that’s OK!

Videos (Short Explanation)

Noticing Suffering Demo

Shows how to identify both visible and hidden signs of suffering in people during daily situations.

Compassion with Boundaries

Demonstrates how to be compassionate without being a pushover, and how to set healthy limits.

Levels of Compassion

ExplainedExplains the three levels—wishing, aspiring, and engaged compassion—using simple real-life examples.

Quizzes (Short Explanation)

Identify Thinking Traps

Scenario-based questions where learners recognize which thinking trap is blocking compassion.

Components of Compassion

Matching questions to connect examples with noticing suffering, empathic concern, and sense of agency.

Levels of Compassion

Learners read scenarios and decide whether they show wishing, aspiring, or engaged compassion.